Understanding Cybersecurity Status Quo

To learn more about the current cybersecurity landscape we have a chat with Nick FitzGerald.

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Certain monitoring websites quantify 84% of the entire traffic originating from India as spam. Could things get any worse?
Spam has evolved over the years. In the past, spam was easy to spot as it tended to offer products or services that recipients had no interest in obtaining. Today, the level of sophistication has grown exponentially. Messages appear legitimate, designed to bait clicks by providing authentic and relevant content.

Delivery methods have changed as well. With the increasing adoption of connected devices in Asia-Pacific and the world, spammers are turning to social channels, in addition to the traditional method of email.

On the other hand, digital adoption in India is progressing at a breakneck pace. It has overtaken the US to become the second-largest smartphone market in the world, according to Counterpoint's Research.

With the growth of attack surfaces and increasing amount of data being placed online, it seems unlikely that the cybersecurity situation will ease anytime soon.

However, defending yourself against security issues caused by spam does not have to be a difficult job. Consumers should take proactive measures – such as being wary of information demanded by apps and keeping your operating systems updated – which are vital in reducing exposure to such threats.

Recently, a lot of ISPs came under DDoS attacks in Mumbai. Speeds were crippled and major ISPs took to blocking certain incoming ports in order to mitigate the attack. Given that such attacks can be performed on any of the commonly used ports, isn't blocking a temporary solution?
In general, withstanding 200Gbps DDoS attacks requires specialist mitigation technology and extensive network redundancy. For best results for an ISP, I imagine that this should be designed into their infrastructure from the beginning, as adding it during an attack is likely to be problematic.

Given that over time both software and hardware adapt to combat known attack vectors, what is the next step in the evolution of cyber attacks?
If we knew that, we'd proactively block it now so it would not work, and thus it would not become the next evolution in cyberattacks!

Seriously though, when security researchers get together over a few drinks, conversation sometimes veers to "nightmare scenario" projections. We generally prefer not to give the bad guys ideas, so these prognostications are not usually discussed further in public.

However, given the increasing damage caused by ransomware recently, several endpoint security solutions developers, including ESET, have developed various essentially proactive defenses against ransomware. To the extent that these succeed, the ransomware threat should abate.

If that happens, a number of cybercrime gangs who have been making substantial money from ransomware will no doubt be inspired to look for, develop, deploy and attempt to perfect "the next big thing" in crimeware. One possible direction that this may lead is described in a speculative article about the possible future intersection of ransomware and the Internet of Things, written by ESET Senior Security Researcher Stephen Cobb, where he coins and describes the term "jackware".

Has there been any unique cyberattack incident in recent history that stood out from the rest?
In my opinion, the Sony Pictures entertainment hack that resulted in at least US$35 million of damages to Sony, and untold reputational damage that is possibly still ongoing, is quite a stand-out event.

Also, the very recent suggestions that the Russian government, or at least Russian government sympathizers, may have been behind the reputed hack of the Democratic National Convention (DNC) is quite a development in international affairs if it can ever be shown to a reasonably degree of certainty to be true.

To read the full review head over to **http://dgit.in/NkFitzdgteset**